SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #23 · MEDIA AND SOCIAL MEDIA

"I must have the latest things to be happy."

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Where it often comes from

Advertising, influencers, and peers keep telling us that the next phone, car, outfit, or gadget will fill the gap. The excitement of a new purchase is real and short-lived, and then the desire resets. Debt and clutter can follow.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these." Jesus said, "Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions." Solomon wrote, "He who loves money is never satisfied by money." The writer of Hebrews says, "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have," because God has promised never to leave or forsake us. Lasting joy comes from the Giver, not the gadget.

> *"Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these"* (1 Timothy 6:6–8).

Also see

> "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'" (Hebrews 13:5).

> "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'" (Luke 12:15).

> "He who loves money is never satisfied by money, and he who loves wealth is never satisfied by income. This too is futile" (Ecclesiastes 5:10).

> "Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (Matthew 6:19–21).

Common self-statements

- I will be happy once I get that.
- My old one is embarrassing.
- Everyone else has the new version.
- I deserve the upgrade.
- Without it I am falling behind.
- The next purchase will satisfy me.

Common logical errors

- Magical thinking: Believing a purchase will change how I feel for good.
- Social comparison: Measuring myself by what others own.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should have the latest.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling a want and treating it as a need.

Challenging questions

- How long did happiness last after my last big purchase?
- What emptiness am I hoping something will fill?
- What do I already have that I once longed for?
- How is my spending affecting my finances and peace?
- What does Scripture say about contentment?
- What would a 30-day pause before buying look like?

Truth summary

> Things cannot fill what only God can. Contentment is a learned gift that frees me from the treadmill. I can enjoy good things without needing the newest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Dissatisfaction
- Greedy/Stingy
- Money
- Thankful
- Worldly

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must have the latest things to be happy"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must have the latest things to be happy." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How long did happiness last?
- ☐ What emptiness am I filling?
- ☐ What do I already have?
- ☐ What is it costing me?
- ☐ What does contentment look like?
- ☐ What can I give away?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Godliness with contentment is great gain.
- ☐ Life is not the abundance of possessions.
- ☐ I already have what I once wanted.
- ☐ God will never leave me.
- ☐ Waiting before buying is wise.
- ☐ Joy comes from the Giver.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **1 Timothy 6:6–8**
  "Of course, godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into the world, so we cannot carry anything out of it. But if we have food and clothing, we will be content with these."
- ☐ **Hebrews 13:5**
  "Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: 'Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you.'"
- ☐ **Luke 12:15**
  "And He said to them, 'Watch out! Guard yourselves against every form of greed, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Enough: Each week, name one thing that is enough and one purchase you paused.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Timothy 6:6–8 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Godliness with contentment is great gain.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Dissatisfaction" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Track the pattern. Write the last three purchases and how long the happiness lasted.
- [ ] Pause before buying. Wait 30 days on non-essentials.
- [ ] Give something away. Donate something you no longer need.
- [ ] Practice thanks. Thank God for one old possession each day.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must have the latest things to be happy": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Enough
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have the latest things to be happy.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I chase the next thing. Teach me contentment, free me from the treadmill, and help me enjoy what I have and share it. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.